Thematic

Theravāda Buddhist philosophy

By Davis, Jake H.

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Article Summary

The Theravāda Buddhist tradition understands itself as preserving the teachings of the historical Buddha. All of these teachings are said to fit within the four noble truths: the pervasive unease that is referred to as dukkha, the cause of this dukkha, its cessation, and the path leading to this cessation. This path begins with cultivating right view, and for many Theravādin teachers, a foundational aspect of right view is seeing that ultimately there is no self. Interestingly, in the early discourses preserved by the Theravāda as the Buddha's own teachings, he suggests that both the view that there is no self and the view that there is a self are equally misguided; the reason he gives for seeing all phenomena as non-self (anattā) is that they do not follow our wishes. While there are multiple contrary views of how to interpret such doctrines, Theravādin philosophical texts also contain resources for holding the diversity of possible interpretations in an inclusive way.

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1. History of the Theravāda

Within Buddhist philosophy, the texts and communities that are identified as Theravādin draw on a particular lineage of oral teachings and commentaries that were transmitted from India to the island now known as Sri Lanka, around 300 years before the Common Era, and written down on palm-leaf manuscripts there. Even as these texts were transmitted in the fifth and sixth centuries CE from Sri Lanka to Southeast Asia, and then globally over the past few hundred years, they have continued to be preserved in oral and then written form in an Indian Prakrit language that has come to be known as Pāli. While some Indic philosophical terms – including *karma* and *dharma* – have made it into the English lexicon from the closely related Sanskrit language, the technical terms used in this article will be given in the Theravādin Pāli forms such as *kamma* and *dhamma*. The Pāli name *theravāda* itself means 'Doctrine of the Elders', reflecting the central aspiration of the tradition to preserve the *dhamma* (doctrine) and *vinaya* (discipline) handed down through the lineage of ancient teachers from the historical Buddha. Both are crucial; the monastic way of life governed by *vinaya* has functioned over hundreds of generations of practitioners from the time of the Buddha through to today, both as the foundational context for practising *dhamma* teachings, and also as the vehicle through which the teachings were preserved and passed on.

The discourses or *suttas* preserved in Pāli by the Theravāda derive from one of a number of early Buddhist lineages of oral transmission; other representatives of these early lineages include textual fragments found in the related Northern Indic language of Gāndhārī (Solomon 2018), as well as the much more complete, translated set of texts found in the Chinese Āgamas (Anālayo 2012, 2015, 2016, 2017). The philosophical themes and commitments of these early Buddhist textual lineages are largely unified among themselves. While understanding itself as remaining true to the *sutta* discourses preserved in Pāli, the Theravādin tradition developed certain doctrinal commitments that are not found in the early Buddhist texts. Nonetheless, on many philosophical matters the early Buddhist texts and the Theravādin tradition remain quite

close, and diverge more markedly from the Yogācāra, Madhyamaka, and other Buddhist traditions that predominate in Tibet, China, and Japan.

Aside from the Buddha himself, the figure whose influence looms largest in the Theravāda world is Buddhaghosa, a monastic scholar and commentator who lived and worked at the Mahāvihāra ('Great Monastery') in Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka in the fifth century CE, about a thousand years after the Buddha. At the time he was writing, Buddhaghosa had available to him a canon of texts in Pāli that included a recension of the early *sutta* discourses, a set of *vinaya* texts of monastic rules, and a set of abhidhamma texts detailing a philosophical psychology whose contents are more specific to the Theravāda. Commentaries on these texts, passed down from ancient elders and studied by Buddhaghosa in texts formulated in old Sinhalese, formed the basis for Buddhaghosa's work and thus for Theravāda orthodoxy.

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2. Dis-ease and the path to release from it

Dukkha, the philosophical concept perhaps most central to Buddhist thought, is the opposite of *sukha*, ease. *Dukkha* refers not only to unpleasant feelings of anguish and suffering, but also to a type of dis-ease or un-ease that pervades human experience. Drawing an analogy to medicine, the first teaching given by the Buddha, 'Setting the Wheel of Dhamma in Motion' (*Samyutta Nikāya* 56.11), treats *dukkha* as a disease to be cured: the dis-ease of *dukkha* is to be thoroughly understood, the cause of *dukkha* is to be abandoned, the cessation of *dukkha* is to be realised, and the path leading to the cessation of *dukkha* is to be cultivated.

To thoroughly understand *dukkha*, what is it that must be understood? Birth, aging, illness, and death are all *dukkha*. Being stuck with things one hates is *dukkha*, and being separated from what is dear is *dukkha*. Not getting what one wants is *dukkha.* In summary, this discourse says, the five-aggregates-subject-to-clinging are *dukkha*.

The five aggregates mentioned here are: (1) physical form, (2) the valenced feeling tone of experience as pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, (3) the categorising, perceiving function of mind that allows verbal report, (4) habituated patterns of mental action that habituate further patterns of mental action, and (5) conscious experience itself. These mental and physical aggregates are in a constant process of arising and passing. By seeing and knowing all these aspects of body and mind as unstable and impermanent, *anicca*, one also sees and knows them also as undependable and uneasy, *dukkha*. And, the Buddha asks in his second recorded discourse (*Samyutta Nikāya* 22.59), is it appropriate to regard things that are uneasy and of the nature to change as 'this is mine, this is what I am, this is myself'? No, the reply comes, for if any of these aspects of body and mind were really who we are, they would not lead to affliction, and they would follow our wishes. But body, feeling tone, perception, mental action, and conscious experience are not bound to follow our wishes, and often change in ways that we would not choose. This is why they are to be seen as not-self, *anattā*.

There is broad unity among Theravādin teachers and texts that the dis-ease of *dukkha* plagues individuals both within a lifetime and across lifetimes. The cause of *dukkha* is craving, for sense pleasures, but also any kind of craving to be, or craving not to be. The cessation of that very craving brings freedom from the dis-ease of *dukkha*; this freedom is the aim of the Buddha's teaching. If the tendency towards craving has not been uprooted in the course of one's lifetime, then these cravings at the time of death will result in being born again into having a mind and body. The Buddha's discourses in the Pāli texts identify the wholesome or unwholesome qualities of heart that motivate one's actions (*kamma*) as resulting in happy and unhappy conditions (see e.g. *Anguttara Nikāya* 6.63). A large variety of rebirths are possible: in the realm of human beings; in the realm of animals as well as other unhappy states; in the realm of spirit beings as well as gods whose lifespans are so long they can be mistaken as being eternal. Yet all beings that exist also cease to exist. As long as one has a mind or body, these stubbornly refuse to be bound by one's wishes. This is one level of unease, *dukkha*. If in addition to having a mind and body one then craves for sense pleasures, for being anything at all, or for not being anything at all, the incessant thirst of this craving results in an additional level of *dukkha*.

The cure for both kinds of *dukkha* is the eightfold noble path: right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right energy, right mindfulness, right concentration. These are 'right' (*sammā*) in precisely the sense that they lead to the cessation of *dukkha*, within one's experience. In the discourse 'To Rohitassa', the Buddha tells us that the 'four noble truths' are to be found 'just within this fathom-long body, with its perception and mind' (*Anguttara Nikāya* 4.45). Theravāda texts and teachers are largely unified in holding that the Buddha's teachings are aimed at a kind of liberation from *dukkha* that is possible for an individual conscious being, within their own 'world of experience', when the latent tendencies towards craving, aversion, and delusion are abandoned in that individual. The steps of the noble eightfold path are not aimed at ending *dukkha* in society or the external world, though individual transformation may have an indirect and positive effect on social conditions.

Right view, *sammā-ditthi*, is the forerunner of other factors of the noble eightfold path (*Majjhima Nikāya* 117). It includes the views outlined above regarding rebirth and the results of *kamma* that pave the way for right speech, right action, and right ways of living. Right view also creates the foundation for the cultivation of right energy, right mindfulness, and right concentration, which in turn create the conditions for release from *dukkha*. So far we have outlined a number of views that are broadly regarded as right by Theravādin teachers and texts. As we inquire into the details of what constitutes right view, however, interpretations can differ.

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3. Two views of non-self

The Buddha's second recorded teaching is the 'Discourse on the Characteristic of Non-self' (*Samyutta Nikāya* 22.59). As noted above, in that text the Buddha suggests that body, feeling tone, perception, mental actions, and consciousness are not permanent (*anicca*), not easy (*dukkha*), and not self (*anattā*).

One dominant thread of Buddhist thought takes this teaching – that none of the aggregates are appropriate to regard as me or mine or myself – as implying a further claim, that there is no self. Within the Theravāda, the development of this interpretation can be traced at least as far back as the conversations with a Greek Bactrian king recorded in the Pāli text 'Questions of King Menander'. In this text, the Buddhist teacher Nāgasena distinguishes between the concept (*paññatti*) of a person and what is 'found' in the ultimate sense (*paramatthato*). He employs the analogy of a chariot: when various parts of a chariot are assembled – the pole, the axle, the wheels, the body, and so on – dependent on these parts, there is the concept *CHARIOT*. Nonetheless, there is no chariot separate from the parts, and none of the parts is a chariot. In the same way, dependent on hair, nails, blood, and other aspects of material form, and dependent on mental phenomena such as feeling tone, perception, choices, and consciousness, there is the concept *NĀGASENA*, 'but in the ultimate sense there is no person to be found here' (*Milindapañha* 28).

In his 1915 *Manual of Insight*, written for an audience of European Buddhists, the influential Burmese monastic teacher Ledi Sayadaw describes how one can observe in the processes of sitting down, laughing, sobbing, and so on, that 'these movements and actions are nothing but the changes in the continua of aggregates' (Ledi 1915/1994: 41–2). While acknowledging the conventional truth that there is a person doing these actions, Ledi directs his readers' attention instead to the level of 'ultimate truth', *paramattha*, which he defines as 'in accordance with what is actual, the elementary, fundamental qualities of phenomena' (Ledi 1915/1994: 13). Enumerating and describing these *paramattha* in accord with the Theravādin Abhidhamma texts, Buddhaghosa's commentaries on these, and the tradition that followed, Ledi lists twenty-

eight kinds of material phenomena and fifty-four kinds of mental phenomena. By observing these *paramattha* in the acts of sitting down, laughing, sobbing, and so on, he suggests, one dispels the wrong view that there is a self.

Interestingly, the Buddha is not recorded in the Pāli discourses using this notion of *paramattha* as an ultimate, basic, aspect of reality to which other, 'conventional' notions can be reduced in analysis. The reason he offers in the 'Discourse on the Characteristic of Non-self' for regarding the five aggregates as not self is that they do not follow our wishes. He does not suggest that we should regard the aggregates as not self because, ultimately, there is no self. Indeed, nowhere in the discourses preserved by Theravāda as the Buddha's own teaching is he portrayed as making the claim that there is no self. On the contrary, in the 'Discourse on All the Influxes' (*Majjhima Nikāya* 2), the Buddha states that the view 'there is a self' and also the view 'there is no self', along with a number of other mistaken views about the self, are 'gone with views, a thicket of views, a wilderness of views, a trick of views, a writhing of views, a fetter of views'.

How are we to fit together, on the one hand, the claim that none of the five aggregates are self, together with this warning against the view that there is no self, both of which occur in the early Buddhist discourses? The 'Discourse on All the Influxes' itself notes that mistaken views about self – including the view that there is no self – arise through inappropriate direction of one's attention. Specifically, they arise through inappropriately directing attention to whether one existed or not in the past, whether one will exist in the future, or wondering about the present, 'Am I? Am I not? What am I? How am I? This sentient being – from where did it come? Where will it go?' Following this lead, perhaps it is a mistake to interpret the analysis of the five aggregates in the Pāli discourses as an answer to the question 'What am I?' Chariots are not like people; people feel and perceive the world through their first-person conscious experience, in a way that chariots do not. Gethin (1986) has argued that the notion of the five aggregates in the Pāli discourses is not intended as an analysis of what a person is, but instead as a phenomenological analysis of lived experience, from within (see also Hamilton 2000). Instead of adopting a third-person perspective on the parts that constitute what I am, we can understand the five aggregate analysis as directing attention in a different way: so as to inhabit one's own first-person perspective more fully, with more precise, calm clarity (Davis 2016). On this interpretation, we do not need to answer metaphysical questions such as 'Am I? Am I not? What am I? How am I?' in order to end *dukkha*. On the contrary, to direct attention to the metaphysical project of establishing what exists and what does not exist is a type of inappropriate attention; it cultivates the kinds of clinging that are the cause of *dukkha*. To end *dukkha*, what needs to be established is attention to presently arising phenomena, so that each aspect of our own lived experience of mind and body shows us that it too is not permanent (*anicca*), not easy (*dukkha*), and not self (*anattā*).

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4. An inclusive Theravādin interpretive philosophy

The 'Discourse on Establishing Mindfulness' (*Majjhima Nikāya* 10) is well known among modern Theravādins. The text describes how a meditator establishes mindfulness in regard to body, feeling tones, mental states, and general phenomena, and offers multiple ways in which one might do this. It describes the meditator as dwelling with awareness directed to each of these areas internally, externally, or both. Or, the meditator dwells watching the nature of these to arise, to pass, or both. Or, the meditator has established mindfulness that 'there are phenomena', merely for the sake of bare knowledge and bare continuous mindfulness. The term *vā*, translated here as 'or', suggests that these are being presented as multiple legitimate ways of practising.

Contemplating the arising nature of phenomena, the passing nature, or both, can be interpreted to mean contemplating the changing nature of the five aggregates, as we saw the Ledi Sayadaw suggest above. The suggestion to contemplate phenomena externally as well as internally also fits nicely with an interpretation on which we are to observe these five aggregates in ourselves and others, from a third-person perspective, just as we might observe parts of a chariot. This brings out a possible weakness in interpretations such as that of Gethin (1986) and Davis (2016), to the degree that these authors emphasise the five aggregates as a phenomenological analysis exclusively from the first-person perspective on lived experience.

The popularity of mindfulness meditation in the modern West can be traced in part to the Ledi Sayadaw, and his efforts at the turn of the twentieth century to make Abhidhamma study and meditation practice widespread among laypeople (Braun 2013). However, in contrast to Ledi's texts, modern secular presentations of mindfulness rarely if ever include the metaphysical claim that there is no self, the contrast between conventional truth and ultimate truth, or the intricacies of Abhidhamma analysis. Nor, as we have seen, are these clearly evident in the early *sutta* discourses attributed to the Buddha by the Theravāda. At times, both modern mindfulness teachings and early Buddhist texts seem to encourage instead a type of bare awareness that does not categorise or analyse (Anālayo 2018). This corresponds with the third possible

approach outlined in the *Discourse on Establishing Mindfulness*: to stop with the simple recognition 'there are phenomena', resting attention on present experience in a gentle and non-manipulating way.

While the Burmese tradition that Ledi was trained in does rely heavily on the analytical Abhidhamma approach, other threads of the Theravāda tradition do not, such as the lineage of Thai forest monastics including the renowned Ajhan Chah. The analytical Abhidhamma approach relayed in the commentarial works of Buddhaghosa is nonetheless so influential that it is taken by many modern Theravādins as the single authoritative, correct interpretation of the Buddha's teaching. However, Buddhaghosa's own philosophy of interpretation seems often to resist this kind of dogmatism. He frequently employs the term *vā* to list multiple different possible interpretations that have been received from the generations of elders who preceded him. In places where the Buddhaghosa and his contemporaries at the school of the Great Monastery of Anuradhapura favour one or another of these received interpretations, this endorsement may be expressed. Yet, Buddhaghosa's explicit aim is to give much greater weight to the views of the Buddha and the ancient elders than to the interpretations that seem fitting from within his own perspective or that of his own historical moment.

Moreover, Buddhaghosa's own approach to philosophy is often more phenomenological and practical than metaphysical, as Heim (2014) has argued. In one part of his influential compendium, *The Path of Purification*, for instance, Buddhaghosa lists a number of practical techniques for ridding the mind of resentment towards someone, enabling one to cultivate friendliness instead. He includes here the practical suggestion to try giving a gift. With this same practical aim of dispelling resentment, Buddhaghosa suggests reflecting on which parts of a person's body or mind one is angry with: the hairs, the nails, the perception aggregate, the consciousness aggregate? 'For when he tries the resolution into elements, his anger finds no foothold, like a mustard seed on the point of an awl or a painting on the air' (Buddhaghosa 1956/2010: 301, trans. Ñanamoli).

Like Buddhaghosa's use of analysis to dispel resentment, the orientation of the Buddha's teachings are fundamentally practical. All the teachings in the early *sutta* discourses preserved by the Theravāda tradition are given with the aim of curing the dis-ease of *dukkha*, through dispelling forces of grasping, anger, and delusion. Later Theravādin interpreters have offered analyses that can be seen as less practical and more oriented to the metaphysical project of establishing what, ultimately, exists and not (Ronkin 2005). Still, a Theravādin philosophy of interpretation can employ the inclusive use of *vā*. To take a central example, according to the Theravāda texts, the Buddha taught that all phenomena are non-self (*anattā*). Either this amounts to a metaphysical claim that a person is ultimately just the aggregates and there is no self, or (*vā*) it means that to direct attention to the question of what a person is is to cultivate a kind of grasping and we should instead attend to the arising and passing nature of experience. One might further hold either of these interpretations of non-self as being the one correct view,

on the basis of faith or a feeling or tradition or reasoning; or (*vā*), taking the Buddha's advice in the 'Discourse with Canki', one might instead hold that in such cases it is not appropriate for a wise person to come to the definite conclusion 'only this is true, all else is false' (*Majjhima Nikāya* 95). Within this diversity of possible interpretations there is also unity: Theravāda philosophers and practitioners of ancient times, and today, agree that grasping itself is to be abandoned, and that the texts preserved as the Buddha's own understanding of this are to be given priority over our own interpretations.

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